anti-aircraft gunnery practice. These training exercises provided a revolutionary alternative to using manned aircraft for live-fire drills, as they allowed gunners to practice engaging moving aerial targets safely and repeatedly.

During these exercises, the Queen Bee was launched from coastal stations and guided remotely from the ground using a radio transmitter operated by a trained controller. The aircraft could climb, turn, dive, and perform evasive maneuvers, offering realistic flight behavior that challenged gun crews to adjust aim and timing. Operators closely coordinated with gunners to measure accuracy and effectiveness. In cases where the drone was hit, recovery operations were simple and cost-effective due to its lightweight wooden construction and low production cost.

The success of the Queen Bee exercises validated the concept of using drones as reusable training platforms and underscored the safety and efficiency benefits of pilotless systems. By 1939, more than 400 Queen Bee units had been produced and operated by both the Royal Navy and Royal Air Force (RAF), forming an essential part of Britain’s pre-war defense training infrastructure. These exercises not only improved anti-aircraft proficiency but also demonstrated the strategic advantages of unmanned flight, leading to continued investment in UAV technology.

Across the Atlantic, similar developments took place in the United States with the Radioplane OQ-2 program during World War II. The US Army Air Corps conducted extensive training exercises using these small, mass-produced target drones to enhance gunnery precision. Operated via radio control and powered by compact piston engines, the OQ-2 offered consistent performance and was easily recoverable by parachute. These drones became central to large-scale military training efforts, with tens of thousands produced for use across multiple bases.